

Metadata Guidance (last updated: 9/1/2026)

The first step in onboarding is to complete your **jurisdiction reporting metadata YAML file**. The metadata file tells U.S. Disease Tracker (USDT) how your jurisdiction organizes and reports surveillance data. USDT uses this information to validate and interpret submitted data and display it correctly on the dashboard. The YAML metadata file documents information such as:

- Case classification date method
- Diseases reported to USDT
- Sub-jurisdiction reporting structure and geographic areas
- Data suppression policies
- Data lag policies
- Technical and data quality contacts
- Other jurisdiction-specific reporting and data quality information

Sub-jurisdiction geography is now included directly in the YAML metadata file; a separate Sub-jurisdiction Geography CSV file is no longer required.

Keep your metadata file current and update it whenever reporting practices or configurations change, such as when adding a disease, changing the geographic reporting structure, modifying suppression or data lag policies, or updating contact information. Contact your onboarding coordinator for information on how to submit your completed or updated metadata file.

Planning and Preparation

Before completing the YAML file, jurisdictions should consider the following:

- **Determine reporting geography.** Identify the sub-jurisdiction level used for reporting to USDT. A sub-jurisdiction may be an individual county or a larger reporting area, such as a health region, public health district, health service area, or planning region. Each sub-jurisdiction is defined by a name, geo_unit, and one or more geographic_areas. Repeat these fields for each sub-jurisdiction that will be reported to USDT.

Reporting approach	name	geo_unit	geographic_areas	Description
Individual county	Bristol County	county	Bristol	The reporting unit represents one county.
Multi-county region	Knoxville-Knox Region	region	Hancock, Hawkins, Greene, Washington, Unicoi, Carter, Johnson	Several counties are grouped into a single reporting region.
Planning region	CT Metropolitan	region	Greater Bridgeport Planning Region	The reporting unit represents a defined planning region rather than an individual county.

- **Identify reported diseases.** Determine which diseases or conditions will be included in USDT submissions.
- **Confirm your case classification date method.** Determine whether your jurisdiction uses [Calculated Case Counting Date \(CCCD\)](#) or a custom jurisdiction-specific date hierarchy. If a custom method is used, be prepared to describe the dates considered, their order of precedence, and the logic used to assign cases to reporting periods.
- **Document data suppression and lag policies.** Identify any rules used to suppress counts or delay data before submission to protect patient privacy.
- **Identify organizational contacts.** Determine who will serve as the primary contacts for technical questions and data quality questions and, if desired, identify an alternate or backup contact.
- **Identify** relevant public URLs that you want shared on the USDT dashboard. Links may include jurisdiction disease dashboards, data portals, or other public resources related to the data being submitted.

YAML Basics

YAML is a simple text format used to store structured information. You can open and edit a YAML file in any text editor. To ensure your file can be processed correctly, follow these guidelines:

- Information is typically stored as **key-value pairs**, where a key is followed by a colon and a value.
- YAML supports **nested structures**, allowing related information to be grouped together under a parent key through indentation.
- Maintain the indentation shown in the template. YAML uses indentation to define relationships between fields.
- Use spaces for indentation. **Do not use tabs.**
- Leave optional sections blank if they do not apply. **Do not remove optional sections from the YAML file.**
- For fields that accept a single value, enter the value after the colon. For example:
jurisdiction: EX
- For fields that accept multiple values, list each value on a separate line beginning with a dash (-). For example:
diseases:
 - measles
 - meningococcus
 - pertussis
- Some sections contain a list of entries with multiple fields. Maintain the indentation and structure provided in the template.
- Text following **#** is a comment or instruction and is not processed as data. Comments included in the template may be left in place.
- The **>** symbol indicates that a longer text value may continue across multiple lines. Maintain the indentation shown in the template when entering these descriptions.
- Boolean fields use true or false. Do not place these values in quotation marks unless specifically instructed.

You can also use a YAML validator to check your file for basic formatting errors before submitting it:

<https://yamlchecker.com/>

YAML specification

The YAML specification table describes each field in the jurisdiction reporting metadata file and provides instructions for completing it.

Field: The YAML field name.

Usage:

- **R = Required.** The field must be populated.
- **C(R/X) = Conditional.** If the specified condition is met, the field is required (R). If the condition is not met, the field is not supported (X) and should not be populated.
- **O = Optional.** The field may be populated when applicable or when additional information would be helpful.

Cardinality: Indicates how many times a field or element may or must appear in the file. Cardinality is expressed as a minimum-to-maximum range:

- **1..1** = must appear exactly once
- **0..1** = may appear zero or one time
- **1..*** = must appear one or more times

Definition: Describes the purpose of the field, how it should be completed, and any additional instructions or considerations that may help the jurisdiction determine what information to provide.

Valid Values: Identifies allowable values, expected formats, examples, naming conventions, or other requirements for how the value should be entered.

Field	Usage	Cardinality	Valid Values	Definition / Instructions
# Jurisdiction Reporting Metadata Template	R	1..1		Identifies the file as the jurisdiction reporting metadata template. Do not modify this header.
# Version: 1.1.0	R	1..1		Identifies the version of the metadata template. Do not change unless instructed to use a newer template version.
jurisdiction:	R	1..1	Use the 2-letter jurisdiction abbreviation from PHVS State FIPS 5-2 (Preferred Alternate Code). New York City should use NYC.	Enter the two-letter abbreviation for the jurisdiction submitting data. This should match the jurisdiction value used in submitted USDT data.
last_updated:	R	1..1	Date in YYYY-MM-DD format.	Enter the date this metadata file was most recently reviewed or updated. Update this value whenever changes are made to the jurisdiction's metadata.
urls:				
- name:	R	1..1 per url entry	Free text	Enter a short, descriptive name for the linked resource as it should appear to the public.
url:	R	1..1 per url entry	Valid public URL	Enter the publicly accessible URL for the resource.
disease:	R	1..1 per url entry	Free text	Enter the USDT disease name associated with the resource (e.g., measles). Enter 'all' if the resource applies to all diseases reported by the jurisdiction.
date_classification_method:				
custom_date_method:	R	1..1	true, false	Indicate whether the jurisdiction uses its own date-selection hierarchy rather than Calculated Case Counting Date (CCCD). Enter true only when a jurisdiction-specific hierarchy or decision rule is used.

Field	Usage	Cardinality	Valid Values	Definition / Instructions
custom_hierarchy_description:	C(R/X)	0..1	Free text	Complete only when custom_date_method is true. Describe, in order, which dates are considered and how the final date is selected. Include enough detail that another analyst could understand how a case is assigned to a reporting week. For example, describe whether onset date is preferred over laboratory date or report date and what happens when a preferred date is missing.
reported_diseases:				
diseases:	R	1..*	USDT-supported disease names .	List each disease the jurisdiction intends to submit to USDT. Use the disease names expected by USDT and ensure they match the values used in the submission file. Include only diseases for which the jurisdiction will provide data. For diseases listed in this section, NNDSS data will not be used to supplement the jurisdiction's data on the USDT dashboard. Therefore, it is important that this list accurately reflects the diseases being submitted. If a listed disease is not submitted, it may appear as zero on the USDT dashboard rather than being supplemented with available NNDSS data.
notes:	O	0..1	Free text	Use this field for information that helps explain disease reporting. Leave blank if no additional explanation is needed.
substate_jurisdictions:				
description:	R	1..1	Free text	Briefly describe how the jurisdiction organizes substate reporting. State the geographic level used and, when useful, how the areas are constructed. For example: "We report at the health-region level; each region consists of multiple counties."
jurisdictions:				
- name:	R	1..1 per jurisdiction entry	Free text	Enter the name that should be displayed for this substate jurisdiction on the USDT website. This value must match the geo_name value used in the jurisdiction's submitted data. Use names that align with Census and ArcGIS data when possible so population and geographic reference information can be matched correctly. If a county, enter the county name as it appears in the PHVS County FIPS 6-4 value set.

Field	Usage	Cardinality	Valid Values	Definition / Instructions
geo_unit:	R	1..1 per jurisdiction entry	Examples include county, region, or another jurisdiction-defined geographic-unit type.	Enter the type of geographic unit represented by this entry. This value must match the geo_unit value used in the jurisdiction's submitted data. Use the same geographic-unit terminology consistently across all entries unless the reporting structure requires otherwise.
geographic_areas:	R	1..* per jurisdiction entry	Geographic names consistent with Census and ArcGIS naming conventions where applicable.	List the underlying geographic areas that make up the displayed substate jurisdiction. For a single county, list that county only. For a region made up of multiple counties or planning regions, list each component separately. Use names that align with Census and ArcGIS data when possible so population and geographic reference information can be matched correctly. If a county, enter the county name as it appears in the PHVS County FIPS 6-4 value set. Exclude the word "County." Use the geographic area names that match the values used in the submission file.
notes:	O	0..1	Free text	Use for additional information about the substate structure that is not obvious from the entries themselves. Examples include naming conventions, geographic exceptions, overlapping areas, changes over time, or situations where a submitted area does not map directly to a standard Census geography.
data_suppression_policies:				
description:	R	1..1	Free text	Describe the suppression policy applied to data before they are submitted to USDT. Suppression should be applied when reporting a count at the requested level of detail would meet the jurisdiction's criteria for protecting patient privacy or preventing disclosure of sensitive information. Describe what triggers suppression, including the applicable count threshold and any other factors considered, such as population size, geographic level, disease, age group or other stratification, or the ability to derive a suppressed value from reported totals. Indicate whether the same policy applies to

Field	Usage	Cardinality	Valid Values	Definition / Instructions
				all submitted data or whether different rules apply to specific diseases, geographic areas, or data elements. Suppression policies are established and applied by the jurisdiction before data are submitted to USDT. If no suppression is applied to data submitted to USDT, state this explicitly.
data_lag_policies:				
description:	R	1..1	Free text	State whether a data lag is applied. If so, describe the length of the lag and the circumstances under which it applies. For example, indicate whether all data are delayed by one reporting week or whether the lag applies only to certain geographic areas or small counts. If no lag is used, enter a statement such as "No data lag is applied."
contact_information:				
technical_contact:				
name:	C(R/X)	1..1	Free text	Enter the full name of the technical contact. Required when the technical_contact section is included.
title:	O	0..1	Free text	Enter the contact's position or job title.
organization:	O	0..1	Free text	Enter the agency, division, program, or organization with which the contact is affiliated.
email:	C(R/X)	1..1	Valid email address	Enter an actively monitored email address for the technical contact.
phone:	O	0..1	Valid telephone number XXX-XXX-XXXX	Enter a telephone number, including area code and extension when applicable.
notes:	O	0..1	Free text	Use to clarify the contact's responsibilities, preferred method of contact, availability, or other information that would help route questions appropriately.
data_quality_contact:				
name:	C(R/X)	1..1	Free text	Enter the full name of the data-quality contact. Required when the data_quality_contact section is included.
title:	O	0..1	Free text	Enter the contact's position or job title.

Field	Usage	Cardinality	Valid Values	Definition / Instructions
organization:	O	0..1	Free text	Enter the agency, division, program, or organization with which the contact is affiliated.
email:	C(R/X)	1..1	Valid email address	Enter an actively monitored email address for the data-quality contact.
phone:	O	0..1	Valid telephone number XXX-XXX-XXXX	Enter a telephone number, including area code and extension when applicable.
notes:	O	0..1	Free text	Use to clarify the types of data-quality or surveillance questions this person should receive, as well as preferred contact method or availability.
alternate_contact:				
name:	C(R/X)	1..1	Free text	Enter the full name of the alternate contact. Required when the alternate_contact section is included.
title:	O	0..1	Free text	Enter the contact's position or job title.
organization:	O	0..1	Free text	Enter the agency, division, program, or organization with which the alternate contact is affiliated.
email:	C(R/X)	1..1	Valid email address	Enter an actively monitored email address for the alternate contact.
phone:	O	0..1	Valid telephone number XXX-XXX-XXXX	Enter a telephone number, including area code and extension when applicable.
notes:	O	0..1	Free text	Use for any additional information that would help USDT staff know when or how to contact this person.
additional_notes:				
jurisdiction_specific_notes:	O	0..1	Free text	Document reporting practices, definitions, exceptions, limitations, or other jurisdiction-specific details that are important for understanding the submitted data but are not captured elsewhere in the metadata file.

Field	Usage	Cardinality	Valid Values	Definition / Instructions
data_quality_notes:	O	0..1	Free text	Describe known data-quality limitations or considerations that may affect interpretation of the data. Examples include incomplete historical reporting, known delays, changes in surveillance systems, or differences in how certain fields are populated.
update_frequency:	O	0..1	weekly	Indicate how often the jurisdiction expects to update and submit its cumulative USDT data file. Use the standard value shown unless a different cadence has been specifically established with USDT.
historical_data_availability:	O	0..1	Free text	Describe the earliest period for which the jurisdiction can provide USDT data. Where possible, provide a specific date or reporting period, for example: Data available from December 29, 2024 onward.
other:	O	0..1	Free text	Use only for relevant information that does not fit naturally in another metadata field. Avoid repeating information already documented elsewhere in the file.

YAML example

jurisdiction:	jurisdiction: {jurisdiction}
last_updated:	last_updated: YYYY-MM-DD
urls:	urls:
- name: url: disease:	- name: StateName Measles Dashboard url: www.statedashboardexample.gov disease: measles - name: StateName Data Portal url: www.statedataportal.gov disease: all
date_classification_method:	date_classification_method:
custom_date_method:	custom_date_method: false
custom_hierarchy_description:	custom_hierarchy_description: > Provide detailed description of the custom jurisdiction date hierarchy. Include the order of dates considered (e.g., earliest date, date of onset, lab date, report date) and logic for how cases are classified in time.
reported_diseases:	reported_diseases:
diseases:	diseases: - measles - meningococcus - pertussis
notes:	notes: > Add any additional notes regarding reported diseases
substate_jurisdictions:	substate_jurisdictions:
description:	description: Example description - We report at the health region level, which includes 9 health regions each comprised of 3-5 counties.
jurisdictions:	jurisdictions:
- name: geo_unit: geographic_areas:	- name: Bristol County geo_unit: county geographic_areas: - Bristol - name: Dukes/Nantucket/Barnstable Counties

	geo_unit: county geographic_areas: - Dukes - Nantucket - Barnstable
notes:	notes: >
data_suppression_policies:	data_suppression_policies:
description:	description: Example-Counts are suppressed when counts are 5 and under and the population is less than 100,000.
data_lag_policies:	data_lag_policies:
description:	description: No data lag is applied.
contact_information:	contact_information:
technical_contact:	technical_contact:
name:	name: Technical Contact Name
title:	title: Position/Title
organization:	organization: Organization/Department
email:	email: technical.contact@jurisdiction.gov
phone:	phone: XXX-XXX-XXXX
notes:	notes: > Primary contact for technical questions about data submission, file formats, transfer methods, etc.
data_quality_contact:	data_quality_contact:
name:	name: Data Quality Contact Name
title:	title: Position/Title
organization:	organization: Organization/Department
email:	email: data.quality@jurisdiction.gov
phone:	phone: XXX-XXX-XXXX
notes:	notes: > Primary contact for questions about data quality, validation issues, data definitions, and data interpretation.
alternate_contact:	alternate_contact:
name:	name: Alternate Contact Name (Optional)

title:	title: Position/Title
organization:	organization: Organization/Department
email:	email: alternate.contact@jurisdiction.gov
phone:	phone: XXX-XXX-XXXX
notes:	notes: Alternate or backup contact if primary contacts are unavailable.
additional_notes:	additional_notes:
jurisdiction_specific_notes:	jurisdiction_specific_notes: > Add any jurisdiction-specific notes, caveats, or additional information that would be helpful for understanding the data submitted by this jurisdiction.
data_quality_notes:	data_quality_notes: > Note any known data quality issues, limitations, or special considerations.
update_frequency:	update_frequency: weekly
historical_data_availability:	historical_data_availability: > Describe the time period for which historical data is available (e.g., 'Data available from December 29, 2024 onwards').
other:	other: Any other relevant information